

BEFORE

As human mental abilities developed, so did beliefs in powers greater than humankind and some kind of afterlife.

ART AND SHAMANS

Early art, such as **cave art and bone engravings** << 20–21, reflects an early human concern with interpreting and trying to influence the world around us through ritual.

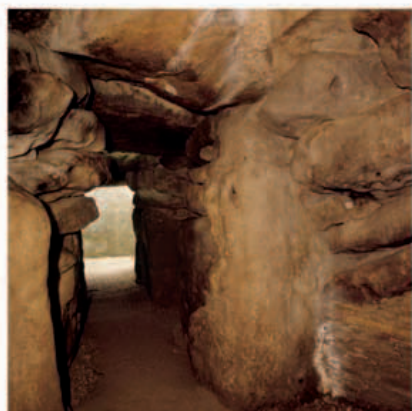
FERTILITY

As farming took hold, societies made fertility goddesses, which indicates a desire to promote growth and life << 30–31.

GRAVE GOODS AND RITUAL

People buried grave goods with the dead from 40,000 years ago << 32–33. Farming communities such as Çatalhöyük, Turkey, had **rooms for ritual associated with the dead.**

ENGRAVED BISON BONE



With the spread of farming across the world (see pp.36–37), an early form of religion developed out of a desire to worship ancestors, and to celebrate the seasons and the cyclical movements of the sun, moon, and stars. The most visible mark of Neolithic beliefs are the spectacular megalithic structures built after 4500 BCE in much of the Mediterranean world and in Western Europe, including Spain, France, Britain, and Scandinavia. Some of these sites are world-famous today.

Monumental sites

There are several types of monuments built using megaliths (“huge stones”) that developed at this time and that continued to be used down to the middle of the 2nd millennium BCE. These include chambered tombs, “menhirs” (single upright stones), stone rows, and stone circles.

In Britain, causewayed enclosures—ceremonial spaces enclosed by banks with multiple entrance gaps—preceded henge monuments, which appeared around 3200 BCE. Henges consist of a circular or oval area enclosed by a bank, but usually have their associated ditch on the inside rather than the outside of the bank, and fewer entrances. Some contained wood or stone circles—Woodhenge in Wiltshire, England, is perhaps the most famous example of a wooden circle. Here, the only

West Kennet

The stone passageway in the West Kennet long barrow, in southern England, leads from a small forecourt to side chambers for the dead. West Kennet was built as a communal tomb c. 3650 BCE.

Creating Stonehenge

In an earlier phase, Stonehenge consisted of a low circular bank with a ditch running along its inside and a row of timber posts along the inner side of that.

remaining evidence of the wooden structure is the post holes into which the timber posts were set.

Stone circles are most commonly found in southwestern England, western Scotland, and northwestern France, perhaps due to the supply of suitable stone blocks in those areas. The stone circle at Avebury, in Britain, is among the largest that survive. The stones may have indicated astronomical alignments and had religious significance. Similar purposes have been suggested for sites of standing stones and rows, such as the rows at Carnac, in France.

Long barrows were mounds used for communal burials. The barrows contained a number of bodies, which may have been exposed before final burial. Some, such as the one at West Kennet, in England, were built with internal stone chambers and used over several generations. Newgrange in Ireland (see below) and Gavrinis in Brittany are other examples of chambered tombs. Some of the stones at these sites are decorated with engraved abstract patterns of spirals, circles, and lozenges, referred to as “megalithic art.” Cigar-shaped ritual enclosures with empty interiors (cursuses) are often associated with barrow sites.

Center of a sacred landscape

The most famous of all the megalithic sites is Stonehenge, England, which was developed, altered, and used over hundreds of years. Like other Neolithic



Rites and Rituals

The megalithic structures of the Neolithic period are awe-inspiring even today, and their mystery adds to their appeal. Frequently associated with burials and seeming to follow lunar, solar, or cosmic alignments, they are strongly tied to rituals linking humans to the wider landscape they inhabit.



monuments from c. 3000 BCE in northern Europe, it was part of a large sacred landscape that included sites of celebration and worship. Hills, lakes, mountains, rivers, and trees were all considered a part of the landscape that defined human existence. Many megalithic structures were constructed at the center of such a landscape and

Newgrange

The entrance to the burial mound in Ireland's Boyne Valley is blocked by this curb stone decorated with the concentric patterns that are common to megalithic art in northwest France and Ireland.

would have been visible from a distance; when newly dug, mounds in chalkland areas would have been quite conspicuous. Stonehenge is close to another circular structure, Durrington Walls, as well as Woodhenge, and a number of burial mounds, including those in the town of Amesbury.

The area around Stonehenge was farmed from around 4000 BCE. Then, in about 2950 BCE, a simple earthwork enclosure was dug containing a circle of wooden posts. Over the next 1,000 years, the site was developed in several stages. The outer circle of stones that we see today was put up by about 2550 BCE. Burials have been found around Stonehenge, along with finds that include amber and bone beads, showing that it was a site central to the rituals of life and death.